

How It Pays for Itself

Funded by members, not advertisers

HIGH DESERT · REDMOND, OREGON

The usual question about an ad-free, two-dollar platform is whether it can survive. It can — precisely because of what it gives up.

WHERE THE MONEY COMES FROM

Members first, advertisers never. A flat ≈\$2/month from verified residents is the anchor — core operations run on dues alone, always — and the price can't rise without a member vote. Around it sit four more streams a nonprofit can reach and a founder-owned company can't: tax-deductible donations, foundation grants, modest earned revenue, and — sequenced last and wrapped in full public disclosure — government money for infrastructure, never for core operations. No single funder is allowed past 30%; no ads and no data sales, ever.

WHERE IT GOES

Into running the thing, which is deliberately cheap: one modern stack, open-source, no growth or ad machinery to maintain, no acquisition spend. Founder pay is staged to the platform's health and set below market — nothing as a side project, a modest stipend at part-time, a full-time salary capped below the founder's academic pay — board-approved and public. Costs scale gently with members; revenue scales with them too.

BREAK-EVEN

Because costs are low and there is no marketing treadmill to feed, the core covers itself at a modest membership — not the hundreds of thousands an ad model needs. At a flat \$2 a month, dues alone carry operations at every rung:

200 members · ≈\$4,800/yr — ≈0.5% of Redmond — the near-term milestone

500 members · ≈\$12,000/yr — an ambitious but real target

1,000 members · ≈\$24,000/yr — core operations comfortably covered

Redmond has about 36,000 residents, so the 200-member milestone is roughly half a percent of town — meaningful density within reach. Everything above core operations — design and accessibility upkeep,

localization, internships, the next town — is additive, funded by the streams that layer on as the nonprofit matures. Grant money is lumpy and slow; it is survivable precisely because nothing essential rests on it.

WHERE THE SURPLUS GOES

Once dues cover the operator, voluntary donations and any surplus flow to local charities through the Community Fund — with members choosing the recipients each year by ranked-choice vote. And because it is a nonprofit with no owner from the first day, there is no exit, no sale, and no conversion to wait for: the lock is in the articles from formation. Success here doesn't mean a fatter margin; it means a bigger gift back to the community.

WHY IT'S DURABLE, NOT JUST IDEALISTIC

The model is sustainable **because** it's bounded, and durable because it's locked. No ad revenue means no engagement treadmill to fund and no reason to enshittify; no venture capital and no owner means there is nothing to sell and no one to sell it. Members are the only customer, so their interests and the platform's are the same. The things it leaves on the table — ads, data sales, hypergrowth — are exactly the things that make most platforms expensive to run and corrosive over time.

It survives by being small, member-funded, and aligned. That's the whole bet.